

Riptide Unified Rights Platform

North Star & Guardrails Memo

Prepared by Math Team — 11/24/2025

1. Purpose of This Document

This document defines the North Star and Guardrails for the Riptide Unified Rights Platform (URP), the core infrastructure intended to power an ecosystem of complementary music companies. Although the terminology is a bit cheesy, the real goal here is to align all stakeholders (Riptide, partners, investors, and contributors) on:

- what we are building,
- why we are building it this way, and
- what boundaries protect the long-term vision.

This clarity ensures the platform grows intentionally, sustainably, and with full ownership of its strategic foundation.

2. North Star: The Vision

Riptide's North Star

To build and operate the central rights and money intelligence layer for the global music ecosystem – a platform that connects contracts, catalog data, works, recordings, registrations, royalties, distribution, sync opportunities, and payouts across multiple companies with one simple login.

In plain language:

Riptide (or the New Company) becomes the rights and revenue plumbing of the music world and partner companies become the apps that plug into it.

In other other words, Riptide becomes (or creates) the Ecosystem Music Company. Defined simply as a network of aligned partners (Revelator, Switchchord, SongHub, Hook Music, and others) each specializing in different aspects of the value chain, all powered by a shared identity-first rights infrastructure that Riptide owns.

This ecosystem:

- handles every aspect of music rights administration,
- scales to millions of works and creators,
- empowers creators at every level,
- increases revenue and reduces costs for partners, and
- creates new revenue streams (sync, insights, creator tools, AI workflows).

To be clear, Riptide does not become everything. Riptide becomes (or creates) the thing everything else plugs into.

3. Core Principles Behind the North Star

1. Identity First

All rights flows are built on one unifying layer: who the participants are.

Every entity (writer, artist, publisher, label, manager, PRO, DSP) must be represented in a clean, deduped, normalized identity graph.

Everything else attaches to identity:

- agreements
- works
- recordings
- catalog shipments
- statements
- licenses
- payments

This identity-first graph is the unfair advantage that makes the ecosystem possible.

2. The Kernel and the Apps

The URP is the kernel.

Partners like Revelator, Switchchord, SongHub, and Hook Music are apps.

- The kernel defines canonical data structures and workflows.
- Apps send and receive data through a defined stable interface.
- The kernel never depends on a single partner for critical logic.

As long as the kernel is stable and partner-agnostic, the ecosystem can grow organically.

3. Own the Core, Integrate the Edges

Riptide must own:

- identity
- works & recordings catalog
- agreements & splits
- royalty ingestion & mapping
- BI metrics & semantics
- payout logic
- user access & permissions
- data lineage & audit trails
- schema definitions (data contracts)

Partners should own their domain expertise:

- Revelator: distribution + real-time usage
- Switchchord: identity + AI contract ingestion/extraction
- SongHub: creator onboarding + collaboration
- Hook Music: remix and UGC engine
- Tipalti: payout rails & compliance
- Accounting tools: General Ledger integration

This division of responsibilities is key to the ecosystem's scalability.

4. Multi-Company by Default

URP must treat Riptide as just one tenant of many.

Why?

- Ecosystem partners must coexist under a shared structure.
- New companies must be able to onboard without re-platforming.
- Investors will likely be more inclined to invest in a platform that serves a broad market, not just Riptide.

"Multi-tenant from day one" is both a product positioning and a revenue model decision.

5. Interoperability Over Ownership

Riptide does not need to "own" every function.

It only needs to:

1. Define the data model,
2. Validate data quality,
3. Orchestrate workflows,
4. Provide insights and settlement, and
5. Serve as the connective tissue of the ecosystem.

This mindset will create speed, partnership, and leverage.

6. Replace FileMaker and Build for the Next Decade

The platform must be built:

- cloud-native
- horizontally scalable
- API-first

- partner-friendly
- modular
- with clean separation of concerns

FileMaker can temporarily serve as a data source, but not a core component.

4. Guardrails: What We Will and Will Not Do

These guardrails ensure Riptide stays focused and protects its long-term differentiation.

A. Product Guardrails

Will do

- Build the rights + money kernel
- Build the unified identity graph
- Define data contracts for all partners
- Own the agreements → works → recordings chain
- Own royalty ingest → BI → payout logic
- Own CWR ingest/export + registrations
- Provide self-admin intake (Portal Lite)
- Develop dashboards and insights
- Provide a sync-integrated licensing view

Will not do

- Become a DSP or a distribution company
- Build OCR or contract extraction in-house (Switchchord's job)
- Become a creator collaboration platform (SongHub exists)
- Build payout rails (Tipalti does this already) - unless, crypto?
- Rebuild what partners already do better

B. Architectural Guardrails

- Canonical schemas always controlled by Riptide
- Events and transformations must be transparent and versioned
- No hard dependencies on any single partner
- All partner integrations must map *to the kernel*, not vice versa
- All workflows must start from identity

C. IP Guardrails

- Riptide owns:
 - schemas
 - data model
 - workflows
 - BI metrics
 - validation logic
 - identity merge logic
 - automation logic
 - terminology
 - interface contracts
 - UX flows

- Partners own:
 - their internal code
 - data they generate
 - proprietary algorithms
 - Joint work has:
 - clear separation,
 - defined contributions,
 - exit/escrow paths.
-

D. Partnership Guardrails

- No exclusivity longer than 12-18 months
 - No transfer of Riptide IP
 - No “co-owned” code unless contractually scoped
 - Adapters must be reversible and partner-swappable
 - Shared roadmap only at the interface level (data contracts, events)
-

E. MVP Guardrails

MVP must remain narrow and intentionally scoped:

Portal Lite → Identity → Agreement → CWR → Statement → BI → Payout

Everything else is post-MVP.

5. What Success Looks Like

Short-Term (MVP)

- A spec'd, demo-ready slice proving interoperability across partners
- Riptide retains architectural control and IP
- Partners understand where they plug in
- Investors understand the long-term moat

Medium-Term (first 12 months)

- 3-5 partners live on the kernel (Revelator, SongHub, Switchchord, Hook)
- Multi-tenant URP powering multiple catalogs
- Unified dashboards for creators, publishers, labels
- First revenue from SaaS + services

Long-Term (vision realized)

The ecosystem becomes THE music company: an integrated network of specialist brands powered by a shared rights + revenue brain.

Riptide owns the rails. Partners add creativity. The system scales infinitely.
